# SUDAN LIBRARY

## PDF Collection Analysis

*Most Impactful Paper  ·  Connection Map  ·  Critical Perspectives*

Focus: Economic Development · Urban Planning

June 2026  ·  Updated with World Bank Sudan Economic Update, May 2025

# ★ Most Impactful Paper

## Recommendation

**Sudan Country Economic Memorandum:** Realizing the Potential for Diversified Development

*World Bank · 2015 · 226 pages*

## Why this paper stands above all others

After reading across the full collection — economic development, urban planning, agriculture, water, heritage, and infrastructure — the World Bank CEM is the clear standout. It is not the most exciting paper in the collection, but it is the most consequential.

### 1. It diagnoses the exact crisis Sudan faces

Sudan lost 75% of its fiscal revenue when South Sudan separated in 2011, taking the oil fields with it. At the same moment, the Gezira Scheme — the 900,000-hectare irrigation system that once made Sudan the bread basket of the Arab world — was so degraded that the President publicly declared it a failure in 2014. The CEM was written at this precise inflection point, making it the most directly applicable document in the collection to Sudan's structural crisis.

### 2. It offers quantified, actionable pathways out

Most papers in this collection diagnose problems. The CEM models outcomes. A 2% increase in crop agriculture productivity would raise Sudan's GDP growth by approximately 1 percentage point per year and reduce the poverty rate from a projected 38.4% to 29.4% by 2030 — lifting millions out of poverty from a single sector intervention.

### 3. It maps the full diversification pathway

The CEM lays out a three-stage development ladder: revive agriculture → build agro-processing → scale into light manufacturing. A sequenced strategy grounded in Sudan's specific endowments and constraints.

#### 4. It identifies the binding constraints precisely

Sudan's fertilizer use: 7.3 kg/ha versus Ethiopia's 17 kg/ha. The real exchange rate overvalued for 40 years, systematically penalizing agricultural exporters. Specific, measurable constraints — the kind you can actually target with policy.

**Key quantified finding:**
A 2% annual increase in crop agriculture productivity → +1 pp GDP growth/year → poverty drops from 38.4% to 29.4% by 2030. Agriculture is not Sudan's past — it is its fastest route to a liveable future.

## Runner-up papers worth highlighting

- **World Bank DTIS (2014):** Sudan Diagnostic Trade Integration Study (158 pages). The most rigorous analysis in the collection of why Sudan's exports underperform. Non-tariff barriers and customs inefficiencies are as damaging as macroeconomic misalignment. Essential companion to the CEM.

- **Agricultural Potential (2001):** The Agricultural Potential of Sudan (Abdalla & Abdel Nour, 9 pages). Maps Sudan's full agro-ecological diversity across six zones with specific crop potential for each. The most accessible entry point into understanding why agriculture is Sudan's genuine comparative advantage.

# □ Connection Map Across the Collection

The 441 papers in this collection form a dense web of reinforcing arguments, shared evidence, and complementary recommendations. Five major thematic clusters:

## Cluster 1 — The Agriculture-Water-Economy Nexus

This is the central cluster. Sudan has roughly 84 million hectares of arable land, of which less than 20% is currently cultivated. Every major economic paper in the collection eventually arrives here. The reason is water — governance, distribution, and access failures.

- **CEM (2015)** → Agricultural Potential (2001): validates comparative advantage claim with agro-ecological evidence
- **Gezira Scheme papers** → Towards Sustainable Water Resources: irrigation collapse → need for integrated water governance
- **Sudan's Struggle for Food Self-Sufficiency** → CEM + Gezira: political economy context for agricultural collapse
- **Nile Water and Agriculture** → Sudan and the Exploitation of the Nile: upstream/downstream geopolitical risk

## Cluster 2 — Economic Diversification and Trade

After oil, Sudan needs new export sectors. The CEM and the DTIS together form the strongest analytical backbone in the collection.

- **DTIS (2014)** → CEM (2015): trade costs as key constraint; reinforces agriculture export priority
- **Chapter 2: Economic Challenges (Nour, 2013)** → Skills Development in Sudan: structural unemployment → skill gap solution
- **Minerals Potential in Sudan** → CEM diversification chapter: gold as transitional revenue while agriculture rebuilt
- **Doing Business 2017 + 2020** → Investment Policy Review: parallel investment climate analyses; converging recommendations

## Cluster 3 — Infrastructure as the Missing Link

Across both economic and urban planning papers, infrastructure — transport, energy, digital — emerges as the binding constraint between Sudan's resources and its markets.

- **Sudan's Infrastructure: A Continental Perspective** → CDD Sector Overview: macro view → gap analysis
- **Sudan Railways** → Sahel Rail + Africa Railways Vision 2025: domestic rail → regional connectivity
- **Khartoum Sky Trains Network** → Khartoum 2030: intra-city transport as urban planning lever

## Cluster 4 — Khartoum: City in Tension

The urban planning papers form a coherent conversation spanning 120 years of planning history: colonial rationalism, petrodollar prestige, and sustainable community-led urbanism.

- **Architecture in Sudan 1900–2014** → Khartoum Urban Area (447pp): historical context for planning continuity and rupture
- **A Glimpse of Dubai in Khartoum** → Khartoum 2030: prestige model vs. sustainable model — the central tension
- **Beyond the Riverside (2020)** → Khartoum 2030 (same author, 2014): riverfront vision → city-wide vision; same framework

## Cluster 5 — Heritage as Economic Asset (The Missing Connection)

Sudan has more ancient pyramids than Egypt, a largely intact medieval port city (Suakin), and an unbroken Nile archaeological corridor. Not one paper in this collection connects these assets to an economic development model.

- **Suakin: On Reviving an Ancient Red Sea Port City (1997)** → CEM diversification chapter: heritage tourism as non-oil revenue; UNESCO listing pathway

- **Dongola Reach papers** → Oxford Handbook of Ancient Nubia: archaeological circuit → cultural tourism itinerary

**The gap — and the opportunity:**
Not a single paper explicitly connects Sudan's heritage assets to an economic development model. The paper that needs to be written: Sudan Heritage Tourism: An Economic Assessment.

# ◈ Update: World Bank Sudan Economic Update, May 2025

Published June 9, 2025 — two days before this analysis was written — the World Bank's latest Sudan report recasts the entire development picture. The 2023 war has not just delayed Sudan's development trajectory; it has collapsed it.

## What the 2025 report says

| Indicator | Figure |
| --- | --- |
| GDP contraction 2023 | **−29.4% (one of the steepest in modern history)** |
| GDP contraction 2024 | **−13.5%** |
| Extreme poverty (< $2.15/day) | **33% (2022) → 71% (2024)** |
| Unemployment | **32% (2022) → 47% (2024)** |
| Inflation (2024) | **170% year-on-year** |
| Displaced persons | **12.9 million (world's largest displacement crisis)** |
| Pre-conflict GDP recovery ETA | **Not before 2031, even with rapid peace** |

## What the 2025 report recommends

The 2025 report's recommendations center on: (1) HIPC debt relief activation; (2) macroeconomic stabilization — unified exchange rate, subsidy rationalization; (3) agriculture as the primary recovery vehicle; (4) infrastructure reconstruction; and (5) trade liberalization. Agriculture is, again, the central pillar.

This is important: even in a post-conflict reconstruction scenario, the World Bank's instinct is the same as in 2015 — agriculture first, then open markets. The implications of this pattern are addressed directly in the next section.

**Why the 2025 report doesn't invalidate the 2015 CEM recommendation:**
The CEM's core argument — that agriculture is Sudan's fastest path to poverty reduction and the foundation for any broader diversification — is actually reinforced by the 2025 data.

The war has destroyed productive capacity, but the underlying endowments (land, water, labor) remain. The CEM remains the most important paper for what Sudan needs to rebuild toward. The 2025 update tells you how much further back the starting line now is.

# ⚠ Critical Note: The Industrial Blind Spot

*The World Bank, the IMF, and most Western development institutions have, across three decades, produced extensive analysis of Sudan's economy. What is systematically absent from every report — including the 2015 CEM and the 2025 update — is a serious engagement with industrialization as a development strategy. This is not an oversight. It is a structural bias, and it has consequences.*

## What the reports do — and don't — recommend

Read across the World Bank's Sudan portfolio (2003, 2015, 2025), the recommendations converge on a consistent set: stabilize the macroeconomy, liberalize trade, invest in agriculture, reduce subsidies, improve the investment climate for foreign capital, and — as a long-run aspiration — develop agro-processing. Manufacturing, industrial policy, and the deliberate construction of a productive industrial base are never the subject of serious, sustained analysis. The word 'industrialization' does not appear as a strategic objective in any of these documents.

### What the East Asian evidence actually shows

South Korea in 1960 had a per capita income roughly comparable to Sudan's at the same time. By 1990, South Korea had become an industrial powerhouse — steel, shipbuilding, electronics, automobiles. It did this not by following comparative advantage into agriculture or commodity export, but through systematic, state-directed industrial policy: infant industry protection, targeted credit, public investment in strategic sectors, and managed trade relationships.

Taiwan, Japan before it, and more recently China followed the same basic playbook. The historical record is unambiguous: the countries that industrialized fastest did so through active state intervention in productive structure — not through market liberalization and comparative advantage. This is not a controversial academic point. It is documented by economists including Ha-Joon Chang, Dani Rodrik, and Alice Amsden, among dozens of others.

### What was done to Africa instead

The 1981 World Bank Berg Report — 'Accelerated Development in Sub-Saharan Africa' — set the template for African development policy for the next two decades. It explicitly argued against industrial protection and state-led industrial investment, prescribing instead trade liberalization, privatization, and a return to agricultural commodity exports. The Structural Adjustment Programs of the 1980s and 1990s that followed actively deindustrialized much of sub-Saharan Africa by removing the protective tariffs and state subsidies that had been slowly building industrial capacity.

In Sudan specifically, the structural adjustment period of the 1990s dismantled what little industrial base existed. Textile mills, food processing plants, and state enterprises were closed or privatized under conditions that prevented their survival. The country that had once exported cotton now imports cotton fabric. This was not a market failure — it was a policy outcome, and Western institutions designed the policy.

### The omission in Sudan's case is particularly glaring

Sudan's agricultural endowments are its comparative advantage — but only if you accept a static, commodity-export conception of development. If you ask a different question — what productive structure would make Sudan wealthy in 30 years, not just reduce poverty in 10 — the answer looks very different. Consider:

- **Cotton** Sudan has a long history of cotton production. Egypt built a textile industry on cotton. Sudan exports raw cotton and imports fabric and garments.
- **Sesame** Sudan is one of the world's largest sesame exporters. Yet sesame oil is processed in Asia and Europe, and the value-added product is imported back. Not one World Bank Sudan report discusses building domestic sesame processing capacity at industrial scale.
- **Gum arabic** Sudan supplies approximately 80% of the world's gum arabic. It is a critical ingredient in food, pharmaceuticals, and technology (used in lithography and as an emulsifier). Sudan exports it raw. The World Bank calls it a 'competitive advantage.' It has never called for industrial development of gum arabic derivatives.
- **Sorghum** Sudan produces enormous quantities of sorghum. Industrial alcohol, animal feed, bio-plastics, and ethanol are all downstream sorghum products. They are not discussed as development opportunities in any of the reports in this collection.
- **Nile corridor minerals** Gold, chromite, iron ore, and other minerals are present at scale. Mining is mentioned in the collection but industrial processing — smelting, refining, value-added manufacturing — is not.

### The framing problem

The World Bank's framing for Sudan has been consistent and limiting: Sudan is a low-income, fragile, agricultural economy. The policy objective is poverty reduction and macroeconomic stability. The pathway is agricultural productivity + market integration. This framing is not wrong — it is incomplete. It describes the floor, not the ceiling.

When South Korea was poor in 1960, no one was asking 'how do we make Korea's rice farming more productive?' They were asking 'what industrial sectors can Korea win in?' That question has never seriously been asked about Sudan in any of the documents in this collection. The closest any paper comes is the CEM's three-stage ladder (agriculture → agro-processing → light manufacturing), but this is presented as a long-run aspiration in two paragraphs of a 226-page report, not as a strategic priority warranting dedicated analysis.

### Why this matters for the collection

Your library of 441 papers reflects this same bias. The economic development papers are almost exclusively about agricultural productivity, trade facilitation, macroeconomic management, and governance reform. There is almost nothing on industrial development, manufacturing strategy, or productive sector policy in the contemporary sense. The one partial exception is the paper on Sudan's infrastructure from a continental perspective, which discusses industrial corridors — but even that frames Sudan primarily as a transit country, not a manufacturing destination.

The paper that is missing from this collection — and from the World Bank's Sudan portfolio — is a Sudan Industrial Development Strategy: what sectors can Sudan realistically industrialize in over 15–20 years, what infrastructure and institutions are prerequisites, and what trade and investment policy is needed to make it happen. Ethiopia has such a strategy (the Ethiopian Industrial Development Strategic Plan). Rwanda has one. Sudan does not, and no major Western institution has offered to help produce one.

*The second paper this collection needs:*

**Sudan Industrial Development Strategy: Sectors, Prerequisites, and Policy**

## ■ Summary

Read together, the 441 papers in this collection make a single coherent argument that Sudan has never fully implemented: it has abundant land, water, agricultural potential, architectural heritage, mineral wealth, and a strategic geographic position. What it has consistently lacked is governance, institutions, infrastructure, and market access.

The World Bank CEM remains the most important paper for what Sudan needs to do first — stabilize, revive agriculture, and establish a foundation. The 2025 report confirms the diagnosis has not changed; it has only gotten more urgent. But the collection, taken as a whole, also reveals a deeper gap: the question of how Sudan moves from agricultural recovery to industrial development has never been seriously asked by the institutions with the most influence over its policy. That question needs to be asked now.

*One paper to read first:*

**Sudan Country Economic Memorandum — World Bank, 2015**

*Two papers Sudan needs written:*

**Sudan Heritage Tourism: An Economic Assessment**

**Sudan Industrial Development Strategy: Sectors, Prerequisites, and Policy**